



NITI Aayog



SECTOR AT A GLANCE 08

# Rural: Menstrual Hygiene Management

WASH in India

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SECTOR AT A GLANCE 08

# **RURAL: MENSTRUAL HYGIENE MANAGEMENT IN INDIA**

WASH IN INDIA

The '**Sector-at-a-Glance**' provides an easy-to-read overview and basic understanding of a sector, sub-sector, or thematic area. The facts and insights on the sector are supported by relevant data and best practices from credible government and multilateral sources. The document covers the structure, key trends, opportunities and challenges, government initiatives, and the way forward for the sector.

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# Overview

Menstrual hygiene management (MHM) refers to access to safe menstrual materials, accurate information, and facilities for washing, waste management, and bathing during menstruation.

Good MHM is crucial for the health, well-being, education, and livelihoods of women and adolescent girls.

However, MHM remains a significant challenge in rural India. Inadequate access to information, products, services, and infrastructure leads to health risks, lost opportunities, and gender inequity for millions of rural women and girls.

Key policy focuses encompass raising awareness about MHM, improving sanitation infrastructure in homes, schools, and public spaces, and addressing societal taboos. Central government initiatives such as the Menstrual Hygiene Scheme under the National Rural Health Mission and the Swachh Bharat Mission (Grameen) are actively involved in rural menstrual hygiene management. These efforts, combined with various state and local-level policies and initiatives, aim to ensure universal MHM and create positive impacts on the lives and livelihoods of rural women and girls.

This note covers key statistics, challenges and opportunities, as well as some ideas for the way forward in improving MHM outcomes in rural India.

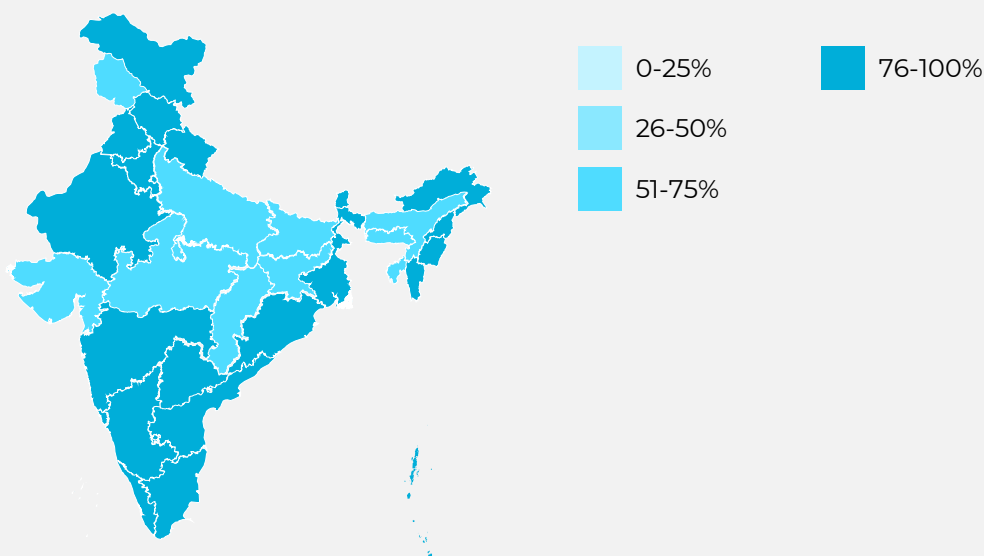
Figure 1: Key rural menstrual hygiene statistics



Source: Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5), 2019-2021; Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers, Suvidha Sanitary Napkins under PMBJP, 2023

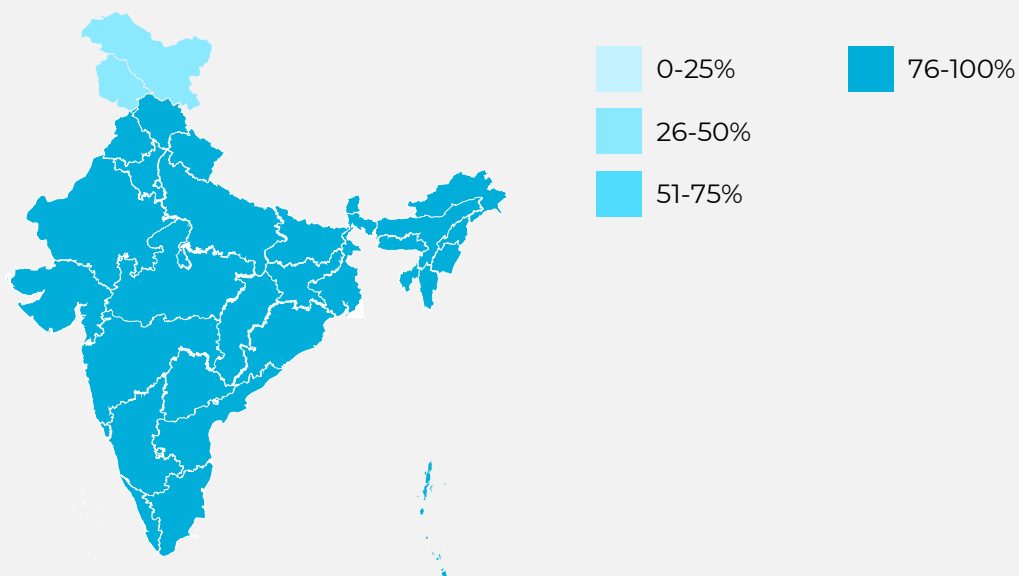
Note: \*Locally prepared napkins, sanitary napkins, tampons, and menstrual cups are considered to be hygienic methods of protection.

Figure 2: Share of rural women aged 15-24 years who use hygienic methods of protection during their menstrual period (2019-21)



Source: Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5), 2019-2021

Figure 3: Share of rural women aged 15-49 who had a menstrual period in the 6 months preceding the survey and who took a bath during their menstrual period (2019-21)



Source: Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey 5.0, 2019-2021

# Opportunities and challenges

## Opportunities

This section highlights the outcomes policymakers can achieve by adopting effective rural menstrual hygiene management practices. These revolve primarily around increased awareness among adolescent girls about MHM, greater access to MHM products and improved educational outcomes.



### **Improved awareness among women and girls, and greater access to MHM products:**

As per UNESCO, 71% of adolescent girls in India remain unaware of menstruation before the first occurrence of menstruation.<sup>1</sup> Community outreach and awareness generation through health workers, women's self-help groups (SHGs), and leaders can promote safe menstrual practices at the household level.<sup>2</sup> Improving access to affordable sanitary products through local SHGs and cooperatives can increase the availability of pads and cloth for households.<sup>3</sup> Further, the distribution of low-cost menstrual products by Accredited Social Health Activists and Auxiliary Nurses and Midwives can directly provide products to women and girls.<sup>4</sup>



### **Improved reproductive health outcomes:**

Menstruation is linked with traditional perceptions and practices, which can sometimes adversely affect reproductive health outcomes.<sup>5</sup> Women and girls with better MHM knowledge are less likely to be vulnerable to these adverse effects, which include reproductive tract infections and fertility issues.<sup>6</sup> Moreover, when access to safe and affordable sanitary materials is improved, the risk of infections is further reduced, improving overall reproductive and sexual health, including better maternal outcomes, lower teen pregnancy, and improved fertility.<sup>7</sup>



### **Improved educational outcomes:**

As per UNESCO, 23 million girls drop out of school in India annually due to a lack of period education and protection.<sup>8</sup> Awareness campaigns and training for adolescent girls and boys on menstrual health and hygiene in schools and Anganwadi centres can build knowledge of safe practices and break taboos on menstruation. Similarly, providing sanitary pads and private changing rooms in schools can ensure girls have access to products and can manage menstruation safely at school.<sup>9</sup> Training teachers to provide menstrual counselling and developing WASH infrastructure like incinerators, washrooms with running water and soap, and separate disposal bins can facilitate safe MHM practices.<sup>10</sup>

## Challenges

This section highlights some of the major challenges and constraints facing rural menstrual hygiene management in India. Efforts to resolve such challenges will ensure the elimination of taboos, equitable access to MHM products and improved sanitation.

<sup>1</sup> UNESCO, WASH Menstrual Hygiene, accessed June 2023

<sup>2</sup> Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Scheme for Promotion of Menstrual Hygiene, 2011

<sup>3</sup> Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Scheme for Promotion of Menstrual Hygiene, 2011

<sup>4</sup> World Bank, Policy Reforms For Dignity, Equality, and Menstrual Health, 2022

<sup>5</sup> National Institute of Public Cooperation and Child Development, Improvement in Knowledge and Practices of Adolescent Girls Regarding Reproductive Health with Special Emphasis on Hygiene during Menstruation in Five Years, 2014

<sup>6</sup> National Institute of Public Cooperation and Child Development, Improvement in Knowledge and Practices of Adolescent Girls Regarding Reproductive Health with Special Emphasis on Hygiene during Menstruation in Five Years, 2014

<sup>7</sup> World Bank, Menstrual Health and Hygiene, 2022

<sup>8</sup> UNESCO, UNESCO Joins Whisper's mission to #KeepGirlsInSchool to ensure girls don't miss out on a promising future, 2021

<sup>9</sup> World Bank, Menstrual Health and Hygiene, 2022

<sup>10</sup> Int. J. Environ. Res. Public Health, Menstrual Hygiene Preparedness Among Schools in India: A Systematic Review and Meta-Analysis of System-and Policy-Level Actions, 2020



### **Prevalence of restrictive norms and taboos:**

In many parts of India social norms restrict menstruating individuals from praying, bathing, sharing beds, or cooking, and sometimes, they are even made to live separately.<sup>11</sup> A report notes that these taboos and myths hinder the optimal use of the 8,000-plus Adolescents-Friendly Health Clinics set up by the government nationwide.<sup>12</sup> Open discussions about safe menstrual practices are limited as menstruation is considered taboo in India.<sup>13</sup> These taboos also prevent women from properly washing and drying their cloth pads, leading to an increased risk of bacterial infections.<sup>14</sup>



### **Inadequate access to affordable and hygienic absorbents:**

An analysis of the National Family Health Survey-5 reveals a correlation between increasing household wealth in rural areas and the adoption of hygienic menstruation methods.<sup>15</sup> Affluent women are most likely to use hygienic methods while poverty is identified as a key factor behind unsanitary menstrual practices.<sup>16</sup> The study also notes that various states have implemented schemes to distribute free or subsidised sanitary napkins at schools but issues such as poor quality and unaffordable were reported.<sup>17</sup>



### **Limited awareness of and involvement by men in effective MHM practices:**

Taboos and a lack of knowledge around menstruation limit men and boys' involvement, limiting their support for creating MHM-friendly environments within households, schools, and workplaces.<sup>18</sup> Emphasising the role of men in MHM could unlock strong psycho-social support for menstruating women and girls and create an enabling environment to address their needs.<sup>19</sup> Greater awareness of MHM can improve access for women to menstrual products and sanitation facilities.<sup>20</sup> Further, advocacy among men can also improve overall awareness of MHM practices and foster a supportive environment for women and girls at home and in public spaces.<sup>21</sup>



### **Inadequate sanitation infrastructure:**

Most women in the rural parts of the country face limited access to clean water, safe disposal, and private sanitation facilities in homes, schools, and public places.<sup>22</sup> This makes it difficult for women and girls to manage menstruation. Public and private investments are needed to upgrade sanitation infrastructure.<sup>23</sup>

11 Karan Babbar and M Sivakami, "Promoting Menstrual Health: Towards Sexual and Reproductive Health for All," ORF, 2023

12 Reproductive Health Journal, Measuring adolescent friendly health services in India: A scoping review of evaluations, 2016

13 MoHFW, Menstrual Health in India: An Update, 2019

14 OpexAxis, Menstrual Health in Rural India, 2021

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20 UNICEF, Menstrual Hygiene Management Programming in Maharashtra, accessed August 2023

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22 Behera MR, Parida S, Pradhan HS, Priyabadi S, Dehury RK, Mishra B, Household sanitation and menstrual hygiene management among women: Evidence from household survey under Swachh Bharat (Clean India) Mission in rural Odisha, India, National Library of Medicine, 2022

23 Behera MR, Parida S, Pradhan HS, Priyabadi S, Dehury RK, Mishra B, Household sanitation and menstrual hygiene management among women: Evidence from household survey under Swachh Bharat (Clean India) Mission in rural Odisha, India, National Library of Medicine, 2022

# Institutional framework and policy landscape –

## Key ministries and departments

This section highlights the major central government bodies and national-level institutions that oversee rural menstrual hygiene management.



### Ministry of Health and Family Welfare<sup>24</sup>

The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare has been implementing the Scheme for Promotion of Menstrual Hygiene since 2011. Through this initiative, the ministry raises awareness among adolescent girls, enhances access to high-quality sanitary napkins, and ensures their safe disposal in an eco-friendly manner.

Moreover, the ministry houses the Department of Health Research which conducts research and studies to explore innovative approaches in handling menstrual health. This includes exploring sustainable substitutes for sanitary napkins and examining their safety, acceptance, affordability, effectiveness, and practicality within public health programs for women.



### Ministry of Women and Child Development<sup>25</sup>

The Ministry oversees the implementation of the Scheme for Adolescent Girls (SAG), wherein one of the aspects involves enhancing the health and nutritional well-being of adolescent girls and encouraging their return to formal education.



### Ministry of Jal Shakti<sup>26</sup>

The Ministry of Jal Shakti, as part of the Swachh Bharat Abhiyan, has formulated National Guidelines on Menstrual Hygiene Management (MHM). These guidelines aim to raise awareness about MHM in rural regions as a component of broader initiatives focused on altering behaviour regarding sanitation and hygiene.



### Ministry of Education<sup>27</sup>

The Department of School Education and Literacy, within the Ministry of Education, oversees the implementation of the 'Samagra Shiksha' programme. This initiative sanctions state-specific projects that include interventions related to menstrual health and hygiene, such as the installation of incinerators and vending machines for sanitary pads.



### Ministry of Rural Development<sup>28</sup>

The Ministry of Rural Development promotes the construction and maintenance of community-based and private toilets and sanitation facilities that cater to menstrual hygiene needs. Additionally, it supports MHM by facilitating access to affordable and eco-friendly menstrual absorbents.



### Ministry of Panchayati Raj<sup>29</sup>

The Ministry of Panchayati Raj focuses on behaviour change programs aimed at challenging societal taboos and stigmas surrounding menstruation. By doing so, it aims to reduce menstrual myths and create a positive and supportive environment for menstruating girls and women.

24 Ministry Of Women and Child Development, Menstrual Hygiene Practices, 2023

25 Ministry Of Women and Child Development, Menstrual Hygiene Practices, 2023

26 Ministry Of Women and Child Development, Menstrual Hygiene Practices, 2023

27 Ministry Of Women and Child Development, Menstrual Hygiene Practices, 2023

28 Ministry of Rural Development Website, accessed April 2024

29 Ministry of Panchayati Raj Website, accessed April 2024



## Pharmaceuticals & Medical Devices Bureau of India (PMBI)<sup>30</sup>

The bureau is the implementing agency of Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana (PMBJP). It aims to ensure access to quality medicines for all and create awareness about medicines; including sanitary napkins.

## Major policies and programs

This section highlights existing policies related to rural menstrual hygiene management and their most prominent features. A more comprehensive list of policies is provided in the policy repository of the NITI for States platform.



### National Guidelines on Menstrual Hygiene Management:

It is a crucial component of the Swachh Bharat Mission- Grameen Guidelines to improve menstrual hygiene practices and ensure access to proper facilities and education.<sup>31</sup> It plays a vital role in supporting adolescent girls and women by outlining the responsibilities of various stakeholders, including state governments, district administrations, engineers, technical experts in line departments, school head teachers, and teachers.<sup>32</sup>



### Menstrual Hygiene Scheme under the National Rural Health Mission:

This scheme aims to promote menstrual hygiene among adolescent girls aged 10-19 years in rural areas.<sup>33</sup> The major objectives of this scheme are to increase awareness among adolescent girls on menstrual hygiene, enhance access to and usage of high-quality sanitary napkins, and ensure the safe and environmentally friendly disposal of sanitary napkins.<sup>34</sup>



### Swachh Bharat Mission (Grameen):

It aims to accelerate sanitation coverage in rural areas which involves establishing facilities for the safe disposal of menstrual waste along with awareness generation about MHM.<sup>35</sup>



### Rashtriya Kishor Swasthya Karyakram (RKSK)<sup>36</sup>:

Implemented by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, RKSK involves the training of teachers and frontline health workers, like Auxiliary Nurse Midwives (ANMs), Accredited Social Health Activist (ASHA) workers, and Anganwadi Workers (AWWs) in MHM.



### Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Janaushadhi Pariyojana (PMBJP)<sup>37</sup>:

Under the PMBJP programme, Jan Aushadhi centres were established nationwide to provide equitable and affordable access to medicines to all Indians. Suvidha Sanitary Napkins priced at Rs. 1 per pad, are also sold at these centres, ensuring accessible menstrual health services for women across India, including rural areas.



### State schemes to support MHM:

Several state governments in India, including Uttar Pradesh (Kishori Suraksha Yojna), Madhya Pradesh (Udita Yojana), Bihar (Kishori Shakti Yojana), Maharashtra (Asmita), Rajasthan (Udaan), and Tripura (Kishori Suchita Abhiyaan), have introduced various schemes to provide free or discounted sanitary napkins in schools.<sup>38</sup>

30 Ministry Of Chemicals and Fertilizers, Suvidha Sanitary Napkins under PMBJP, 2023

31 Ministry of Drinking Water and Sanitation, Menstrual Hygiene Management, 2015

32 Ministry of Drinking Water and Sanitation, Menstrual Hygiene Management, 2015

33 Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Scheme for Promotion of Menstrual Hygiene, 2016

34 Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Scheme for Promotion of Menstrual Hygiene, 2016

35 Ministry of Drinking Water and Sanitation, Guidelines For Swachh Bharat Mission Gramin, 2017

36 Ministry Of Women and Child Development, Menstrual Hygiene Practices, 2023

37 Ministry Of Chemicals and Fertilizers, Suvidha Sanitary Napkins under PMBJP, 2023

38 National Library of Medicine, BMC Public Health, Menstrual hygiene practices among adolescent women in rural India: a cross-sectional study, 2022

# Way forward

While the availability of products has expanded via a range of programs and awareness has also increased due to mass media and IEC efforts, persistent gaps in social attitudes, infrastructure, waste management and monitoring mechanisms continue to impede universal and safe uptake of MHM practices in rural India.

Some ideas that can accelerate progress going forward include:

|                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|  <p><b>Sustaining IEC campaigns</b></p>                           | <p>Sustaining social and behavioural change communication via vernacular campaigns, involving male members, leaders and healthcare workers. Messaging must tackle taboos while explaining biology and hygienic practices.</p> |
|  <p><b>Advancing universal and affordable access</b></p>          | <p>Universalizing access to affordable menstrual products by mobilizing women's collectives for localized production.</p>                                                                                                     |
|  <p><b>Enhancing school infrastructure</b></p>                  | <p>Upgrading WASH infrastructure in schools by ensuring functional toilets, incinerators, and vending machines.</p>                                                                                                           |
|  <p><b>Enabling data-driven monitoring and policymaking</b></p> | <p>Monitoring key process and output indicators on MHM awareness, product uptake and scheme coverage through rigorous studies.</p>                                                                                            |
|  <p><b>Supporting inclusive product innovation</b></p>          | <p>Promoting industry participation for innovating on product designs that suit rural contexts and are eco-friendly</p>                                                                                                       |

# Recommended readings

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